

■ By Dillip Bobb with Vikrant Gupta in Sydney

To think that the biggest crisis in international cricket since Forfeitgate started with an absent minded gesture meant to convey "hard luck mate". Brett Lee had just sent down a searing over to Harbhajan Singh and his last, best ball had been hit for a boundary by the inflammable Indian off-spinner. 'Bhaji' and 'Binga' are genuine friends, the Aussie pace bowler well acquainted with colourful Hindi and Punjabi

The exchange between Symonds and Harbhajan is now at the core of the crisis that has engulfed the game, ruined many reputations, enhanced a few, brought the role of umpires and match referees into sharp and uncomfortable focus and eventually raised more questions than it has answered.

After a two day stand-off, the Indian team left their downtown Sydney hotel, a short 10-minute stroll from the famous Harbour, for the open spaces of the Australian capital Canberra. They play a three-day practice match at the Manuka Oval, named after an aborigi-

nal word for 'echo'—and despite the relaxed smiles at pre-match practice, the reverberations from Sydney could still be heard. On the local Sky News, Ishant Sharma was being highlighted using a Hindi profanity starting with 'b' with a voice-over stating that it was a word whose translation was "more incriminating" than the "bastard" that Brad Hogg had been charged with. The Indians were not amused, a member of the management saying "If they take it up...we will give them five more words." The unspoken threat emanating from the Indian camp is that unless

CRICKET'S BIGGEST CRISIS

The India-Australia series degenerates into an ill-tempered, scrappy, controversial contest and raises questions over the future of the game and those who supervise it

abuses from his many trips to India. After the boundary, Harbhajan tapped the sweaty paceman on his rear in commiseration. Lee walked away wordlessly from the scene and the story, which is when Andrew Symonds stepped in to demand why the Indian was "hitting" his teammate. And to shake the cricket world by its roots.

The conflagration from Sydney has threatened a tour, cricket relations between the game's financial and sporting giants, the standing of ICC as the world's governing body and the reputation of the most formidable team the world has known.

The immediate crisis—which would have led to the Indians pulling out of the series and its attendant consequences—may have been averted by some nimble-footed diplomacy on the part of ICC and BCCI but its fall-out threatens to have a far-reaching impact on the future of the game, players' conduct on and off the field, rivalry between teams, racism in the sport and how its rules will be enforced and by whom.

AP PHOTO/BOB GRIFITH FILES



BAD BLOOD:
Ricky Ponting
confronts
Harbhajan and
Sachin in
Sydney.